Lead Broker Blueprint

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Module 5

The Lead Generation Side

What this module does

Module 5 is the supply-side counterpart to Module 4. Where Module 4 was about selling leads, Module 5 is about producing them: traffic sources, conversion mechanics, landing-page design, intake and qualification, and the unit economics that decide whether a lead-gen operation lives or dies.

By the end of the module you can: choose traffic sources sensibly for your chosen vertical; describe what a converting landing page actually looks like; build an intake protocol fit for your sub-vertical; and run the CAC/LTV math from both sides of the transaction.

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Module 5 overview

Seven lessons:

- 5.1 Traffic source overview.
- 5.2 Paid search deep dive.
- 5.3 Paid social deep dive.
- 5.4 SEO and content.
- 5.5 Landing page anatomy.
- 5.6 Intake and qualification.
- 5.7 Unit economics.

Three deliverables: annotated landing-page anatomy examples, intake script templates for 3–4 verticals, and a unit economics calculator spreadsheet.

Lesson 5.1 — Traffic source overview

> **Learning objective**
> Name the major traffic sources, recognize their strengths and weaknesses, and pair each with the verticals where it does and does not work.

The seven sources, briefly

Paid search (Google Ads, Bing/Microsoft Ads)

Intent-based traffic. The consumer typed a query expressing the problem your service solves. Strongest converter; also the most expensive on a CPC basis. Dominant traffic source for legal, home services, and B2B SaaS at scale. Google Ads commands ~80%+ of paid search volume in the U.S.; Bing/Microsoft Ads is smaller but often cheaper for the same keyword.

Paid social (Meta, TikTok, LinkedIn, Snapchat, X)

Interruption traffic. The consumer was not searching; you interrupted their feed with an offer. Lower intent than paid search; works best for emotional or impulse verticals (debt relief, certain mass torts, beauty, weight-loss) and for B2B (LinkedIn specifically). Meta is the dominant U.S. paid-social platform by spend; LinkedIn is the only meaningful B2B platform.

SEO and organic content

Slowest to build, highest margin once established. Compounding value over time. Major in mortgage comparison, insurance comparison, and some local services. The 2024–2025 Helpful Content Update and the introduction of AI Overviews changed traffic dynamics significantly; thin-content lead-gen sites lost meaningful share, deeper editorial properties largely held.

Email and SMS

Either to owned lists or rented placements. Major in financial services, insurance, and education. Regulated under CAN-SPAM (email) and TCPA (SMS); marketing texts to mobile numbers require PEWC for autodialer/prerecorded sending.

Affiliate networks

Independent publishers and media buyers running traffic to your offer in exchange for per-lead or per-converted-customer compensation. Major in insurance, finance, and education. Quality varies enormously; affiliate audits and consent-record diligence are essential.

Outbound B2B

Cold email, cold calling, LinkedIn outreach. Operationally distinct from consumer lead generation. The skill set is closer to SDR work than to media buying. Important for B2B verticals where buying signal is sparse.

Co-registration paths

The consumer fills out one form and is opted into multiple offers in the same flow. Historically common; increasingly disfavored from a compliance perspective. Many sophisticated buyers no longer accept co-reg leads, especially after the (vacated) FCC one-to-one rule made the practice contractually risky.

On-camera summary

Seven traffic sources. Paid search converts best but costs most. Paid social is for emotional verticals and B2B (LinkedIn). SEO compounds slowly and rewards depth. Email/SMS, affiliate, outbound, and co-reg fill specific niches. Pick the source that fits both your vertical and your skill set.

Sources

- WordStream/LocaliQ Search Advertising Benchmarks (annual).
- Meta and LinkedIn published advertising benchmarks.
- Google Search Central Helpful Content and AI Overviews documentation.

Lesson 5.2 — Paid search deep dive

> **Learning objective**
> Explain why CPLs in legal and home services are so high, recognize the difference between high-intent and research-stage keywords, and articulate why negative keywords are the most-skipped lever in paid search.

Why some verticals' CPCs run wild

Top-of-page CPCs on the highest-intent legal terms in major metros routinely run $50–200+. Roofing's CPL ranks among the highest in home services for the same reason: small numbers of high-LTV-per-customer buyers bidding aggressively against each other. The CPC is set by the marginal buyer's CAC math, not by Google's algorithm; if a personal injury law firm can profitably pay $400 per click on a top-intent term, that's what the top of the page costs.

High-intent vs research-stage

- High-intent: "car accident lawyer Atlanta," "emergency plumber near me," "sell my house fast," "Medicare advantage plan enrollment." Consumer is ready to transact or close to it; conversion rates are higher; CPCs are higher.
- Research-stage: "do I have a personal injury case," "signs my HVAC needs replacement," "what is mortgage refinance." Consumer is gathering information; conversion is lower; CPCs are meaningfully lower.

Most lead-gen operations build their funnel around high-intent terms because the LTV math supports the CPL. Research-stage terms work when paired with a longer nurture flow (typically email).

The most-skipped lever: negative keywords

What operators say works: *ask any media-buying operator on a podcast and they'll name negative keywords as the single most under-used lever in paid search. Adding negative keywords ("free," "job," "definition," "DIY," "reviews" — vertical-specific) prevents your ads from showing on queries that won't convert, which dramatically improves your ROI without changing anything else. Most operators audit their negative-keyword list quarterly; the audit usually produces a 10-20% CAC improvement.*

Google's Local Services Ads

Google's Local Services Ads (LSA) is a pay-per-lead product that competes with traditional Google Ads for many service verticals (home services, legal, etc.). LSA prices leads through an auction system; ads appear above traditional search ads with a Google-vouched badge. For service businesses, LSA changes the competitive picture: a contractor running LSA can sometimes get cheaper leads through Google than

through a third-party lead-gen operator. The implication for newcomers: in LSA-active sub-verticals, the value proposition needs to be more than just "we get you leads"; it has to be reliable volume, specific qualification, or geographic depth that LSA doesn't replicate.

On-camera summary

Paid search converts well, costs a lot, and rewards discipline on negative keywords. High-intent terms drive most lead-gen funnels. Local Services Ads has changed competitive dynamics in service verticals; build a value proposition that goes beyond "we get you leads."

Sources

- WordStream/LocaliQ Search Advertising Benchmarks (annual).
- Google Ads and Local Services Ads public documentation.

Lesson 5.3 — Paid social deep dive

> **Learning objective**
> Explain why social converts differently from search, recognize creative cycle / audience fatigue dynamics, and pair paid social with the right verticals (and avoid the wrong ones).

Interruption vs intent

Social ads interrupt a consumer who was doing something else. Conversion rates per impression are far lower than search; volumes are far higher. The math works when (a) creative is strong enough to interrupt; (b) the offer is emotional or impulse-driven enough to convert without prior intent; and (c) the audience is broad enough to scale.

Creative cycles and audience fatigue

Paid social creative degrades faster than paid search creative. A high-performing Meta ad typically peaks within 2–6 weeks before its CPM (and resulting CPL) climbs. The operator's job is continuous creative refresh — testing new variations, retiring fatigued creative, rotating offers. Operators publicly describe paid social as "a creative-production business with a media-buying layer" rather than the other way around.

Where social works

- Emotional verticals: debt relief, mass tort plaintiffs (specific litigations like 3M earplugs, Roundup, Camp Lejeune), final expense, weight-loss programs.
- Beauty and aesthetics: med spa, cosmetic surgery, dental implants.
- B2B (LinkedIn specifically): SaaS, professional services, account-based marketing. Other social platforms do not work for B2B at any meaningful scale.

Where social struggles

- High-intent service verticals where the consumer needs the service now (emergency plumbing, urgent legal — they search, not scroll).
- B2B on non-LinkedIn platforms — Meta, TikTok, and X have not produced sustained B2B funnels.
- Highly regulated verticals where creative compliance is strict (insurance Medicare during AEP, mortgage, certain financial services). Permissible creative is narrow; the platform's content rules add another constraint.

On-camera summary

Paid social is interruption traffic. Emotional and impulse verticals work; high-intent service verticals don't. Creative degrades quickly; refresh continuously. LinkedIn is the only meaningful B2B paid-social channel.

Sources

- Meta Ads Manager and LinkedIn Campaign Manager benchmarks.
- Operator commentary across paid-social practitioner content (e.g., Andrew Chen, Common Thread Collective, Foreplay Co.).

Lesson 5.4 — SEO and content

> **Learning objective**
> Articulate why SEO is the slowest but highest-margin traffic source, describe the Google algorithm changes of 2024–2025 (Helpful Content Update and AI Overviews) and their impact on lead-gen sites, and decide whether SEO is a sensible play for your vertical.

The economics of SEO

SEO produces traffic without a marginal cost per click — the cost is in content creation, technical infrastructure, and time. Once a page is ranking, additional traffic is essentially free. Margins on SEO-sourced leads are therefore higher than margins on paid-source leads in the same vertical.

The trade-off: SEO is slow. Most lead-gen verticals see meaningful SEO results 9–18 months after content investment begins. For an operator that needs revenue in the first six months, SEO cannot be the primary channel; it can be the second or third channel that compounds over time.

Local SEO vs national SEO

- Local SEO: ranking in a single metro or set of metros for service-area queries ("plumber Atlanta," "car accident lawyer Phoenix"). Faster to build than national SEO; rewards Google Business Profile optimization, local citations, and review acquisition. Most home-services and local-legal operators run local SEO as a primary or major channel.
- National SEO: ranking for non-geo-specific queries ("best mortgage rates," "how to file for bankruptcy"). Slower, more competitive, but higher ceiling. Used by comparison sites (LendingTree, NerdWallet, MoneyGeek) and the largest aggregators.

The 2024-2025 Google algorithm reset

Helpful Content Update (HCU) and its successors

Google's Helpful Content Update (2022 onward, repeatedly refined through 2024) targets content that exists primarily to rank in search rather than to serve readers. Thin lead-gen pages built around keyword-stuffed listicles lost substantial traffic share through 2024. The operators who survived had editorially substantive content (real depth, citations, unique perspective); the operators who lost the most were running templated content farms.

AI Overviews

Google's AI Overviews (launched 2024) generates short AI-written summaries above traditional search results for many queries. The impact on lead generation has been twofold: (a) zero-click queries (consumer reads the AI summary and never clicks through) have grown for informational searches; (b)

high-intent transactional queries are less affected — when the consumer wants "car accident lawyer near me," they still click through. The implication for SEO operators: research-stage content has lost some value; high-intent commercial content has held value better.

On-camera summary

SEO is slow and compounding. The 2024-2025 Google reset has rewarded substantive content and punished thin content. Local SEO is more accessible than national; high-intent commercial content has held value better than research-stage content under AI Overviews.

Sources

- Google Search Central documentation (Helpful Content System; AI Overviews).
- Sistrix, Ahrefs, Semrush published visibility-shift analyses (2023-2025).
- Local SEO Guide and Whitespark research on local-pack ranking factors.

Lesson 5.5 — Landing page anatomy

> **Learning objective**
> Identify the components of a converting lead-gen landing page, describe what does and does not convert with annotated examples, and articulate the form-length vs lead-quality trade-off.

The seven components

1. Hero / above-the-fold offer. One sentence stating what you do and one CTA. Headline should mirror the search query (or the social ad copy) that brought the visitor here. Visual: clean; no stock-photo handshakes.
2. Compliance disclosure (and consent capture if the page collects PEWC). The PEWC disclosure must be clear and conspicuous; do not bury it. The signature/checkbox must be on the page where consent is captured, not on a downstream page.
3. Trust signals. Real trust signals: BBB ratings (real), industry-specific certifications, named cases or projects (if applicable). NOT trust signals: stock-photo testimonials, fabricated reviews, AI-generated review-style content (prohibited under the FTC Reviews Rule — Module 3.7).
4. Form. The fewer fields, the higher the conversion rate — and the lower the lead quality. Industry conventional wisdom: 4-7 fields for shared form leads; 8-15 fields plus qualification questions for exclusive or CPA leads.
5. Phone CTA. A phone number prominently displayed for consumers who prefer to call. Click-to-call on mobile. Tracking number for attribution.
6. Secondary content. Brief explanation of what happens after submission: how soon they'll be contacted, by whom, what to expect on the call. Reduces post-submission disappointment and improves intake conversion.
7. Footer compliance. Privacy notice, terms of service, do-not-sell-or-share opt-out link (CCPA and equivalents), business address (CAN-SPAM compliance for any email follow-up).

The form-length / lead-quality trade-off

Each additional form field reduces submission rate by roughly 10-25% (operators publicly cite this range, with substantial variation by vertical and creative). Each additional qualification question increases the lead quality of the submissions you do get. The right balance depends on the buyer's specifications and the unit economics of the funnel:

- Shared-form-lead funnels: keep forms short (4-7 fields); accept lower per-lead quality; sell to buyers comfortable with shared volume.
- Exclusive-lead funnels: longer forms (8-15 fields) with qualification questions; smaller volume of higher-quality submissions.

- Pay-per-call and CPA funnels: very short forms or click-to-call; qualification happens on the phone, not on the page.

Multi-step funnels

Splitting a long form across multiple pages ("What's your zip code?" → "What service do you need?" → "Tell us about the project" → contact info) consistently outperforms single long forms — operators publicly cite 15–40% higher completion rates for multi-step vs. single-page equivalents. The trade-off is engineering complexity and tracking; modern landing-page tools (Unbounce, Instapage, Leadpages, plus the major form builders) make multi-step funnels easy to build.

What does not convert

- Stock-photo testimonial blocks — both legally exposed (FTC Reviews Rule) and ineffective (consumers recognize them).
- AI-generated reviews or testimonials — prohibited under the FTC Reviews Rule; also reduces trust when consumers detect them.
- Auto-playing video or audio — high bounce rates.
- Pop-ups before the consumer can read the page — high bounce rates and lower-quality submissions when they do.
- Required phone before email or vice versa — consumers protect their phone; allow some flex on field order.
- Demands for sensitive personal data without clear purpose (SSN, full DOB, financial account numbers) — submission rates collapse.

On-camera summary

A converting lead-gen landing page is short, clear, compliant, and matched to the source of the traffic. Form length is the main quality lever; shorter forms produce more, lower-quality leads. Multi-step funnels outperform single-page equivalents. Stock testimonials and AI-generated content are now both prohibited and ineffective. The annotated landing page anatomy examples (Module 5 deliverable) make this concrete.

Sources

- Unbounce, Instapage public conversion-benchmark reports.
- Nielsen Norman Group landing-page UX research.
- FTC Reviews Rule, 16 C.F.R. Part 465 (Module 3.7).

Lesson 5.6 — Intake and qualification

> **Learning objective**
> Distinguish form-based, phone-based, and live-transfer intake; design qualification questions specific to your vertical; and design an intake script structure that produces consistent qualified leads.

Three intake modes

- Form-based intake. Consumer fills out the form; lead is delivered to buyer; buyer's intake calls. The seller's role is the form design and validation. Lowest seller-side operational cost.
- Phone-based intake (the seller calls). The seller's call center or agent calls the form-submitter to verify and qualify before delivering the lead to the buyer. Higher seller-side cost; higher lead quality; sometimes higher per-lead pricing as a result.
- Live transfer / warm transfer. The seller's call center qualifies the consumer on the phone (either after the consumer called in to the seller's number, or after the seller called out to a submitted contact), then transfers the live call to the buyer.

Qualification questions by vertical

These vary wildly. A few examples:

Personal injury

- When did the accident occur? (Within X months disqualifies depending on statute of limitations.)
- Were you injured?
- Did you receive or are you currently receiving medical treatment?
- Have you already retained an attorney?
- Were you at fault?

HVAC replacement

- Are you the homeowner / owner of the property?
- What is the age of your current HVAC system?
- What is your timeline for replacement?
- What is your service area / zip code?
- Are you currently working with another contractor on this project?

Medicare

- Are you 65 or older, or qualifying for Medicare?

- Are you currently enrolled in original Medicare, Medicare Advantage, or neither?
- Are you within an applicable election period? (AEP, IEP, SEP)
- What is your zip code?
- Do you have prescription drug coverage now?

Mortgage purchase

- What is your timeline for purchasing?
- Have you been pre-approved for a mortgage?
- What is your approximate credit score range?
- What is your approximate household income?
- Do you have a property identified or are you in the search phase?

Intake script structure

A consistent structure helps human agents stay disciplined and improves qualified-lead conversion. Five-part structure:

8. Opening. Confirm name, thank for submission, set context ("I'm following up on the [service] inquiry you submitted at [time]").
9. Permission. Confirm it's a good time to talk for 2-3 minutes. If not, schedule.
10. Qualification questions. In a defined order, with hard-stop scripts for disqualifying answers.
11. Next step. For qualified: introduce the buyer, set expectation for the buyer's call timing, transfer or schedule. For disqualified: polite close with note that the consumer may hear from other parties if shared.
12. Wrap. Confirm contact info; thank; end the call.

On-camera summary

Three intake modes; choose based on price tier, vertical, and operational capacity. Qualification questions are vertical-specific and shouldn't be improvised. Script structure helps human agents stay disciplined. The intake script templates (Module 5 deliverable) cover four verticals: PI, HVAC, Medicare, and mortgage.

Sources

- Operator commentary at LeadsCon, Mass Torts Made Perfect, Service World Expo.
- LeadsCouncil intake best-practices materials.

Lesson 5.7 — Unit economics

> **Learning objective**
> Run the CAC/LTV math from both sides of the transaction. Articulate why an "expensive" lead is sometimes profitable for the buyer and a "cheap" lead is sometimes unprofitable.

The chain

From supply-side ad spend to buyer-side acquired customer:

13. Supply-side CPL = (ad spend + creative + landing-page costs + intake-call labor + tooling) / leads produced. Includes everything to produce one lead.
14. Buyer-side CPL = price the buyer pays the seller (or the chain, if there are layers in between).
15. Buyer's CAC = buyer-side CPL × leads per converted customer = buyer-side CPL / lead-to-customer conversion rate.
16. Buyer's margin = LTV − CAC − other variable costs of serving the customer.

Why "expensive" leads are sometimes profitable

Worked example, personal injury exclusive leads:

- Buyer-side CPL: $400.
- Lead-to-signed-case conversion: 20% (strong intake).
- Buyer's CAC: $400 / 20% = $2,000.
- Average net case fee: $17,500.
- Buyer's gross margin per signed case: $15,500. Profitable.

Why "cheap" leads are sometimes unprofitable

Worked example, auto insurance shared leads:

- Buyer-side CPL: $12.
- Lead-to-policy conversion: 4% (intake is fine, but most consumers are shopping multiple carriers).
- Buyer's CAC: $12 / 4% = $300.
- Average annual policy revenue: $1,200; carrier's gross margin on policy: 8% = $96 first year, $96 × retention years = LTV roughly $250-350.
- Net margin: tight to negative, depending on retention. The "cheap" lead can be unprofitable at production cost.

The most important variable: conversion rate

Across both worked examples, the variable that controls CAC most powerfully is the conversion rate, not the lead price. A 20% conversion at $400 = $2,000 CAC; a 10% conversion at $200 = $2,000 CAC; a 5% conversion at $100 = $2,000 CAC. The buyer's intake operation determines which combination is producing the right CAC for their LTV.

Supply-side unit economics

From the seller's side, the math runs in reverse. To produce a lead at $50 of supply CPL profitably, the seller needs to sell it for at least $80–100 to clear margin after platform fees, processing, and overhead. The shape of the gross margin determines which channels are sustainable.

- Paid search supply CPL: $30-100 typical, depending on vertical.
- Paid social supply CPL: $20-80.
- SEO supply CPL: $5-30 (once established; much higher in the ramp phase).
- Outbound B2B supply CPL: highly variable, often $40-200 depending on ICP and process maturity.

On-camera summary

Unit economics runs both ways. The buyer cares about CAC vs LTV; the seller cares about supply CPL vs sale price. The dominant variable on the buyer's CAC is conversion rate, not lead price. The unit economics calculator spreadsheet (Module 5 deliverable) lets you walk through your own numbers from both sides.

Sources

- Module 1.5 (the CAC/LTV reasoning underlying the industry's structure).
- Public earnings disclosures of QuinStreet, MediaAlpha, EverQuote, Angi.
- Module 5 deliverable: Unit Economics Calculator.

Module 5 wrap-up and what's next

You've now covered traffic sources, paid search and paid social specifics, SEO, landing page anatomy, intake and qualification, and unit economics from both sides. The three deliverables operationalize the lessons.

What Module 6 covers

Module 6 is the operational stack: the minimum viable tech stack, lead distribution platforms, call tracking, consent capture and verification, team structure as you scale, and the common operational pitfalls. After Module 6, you'll have a complete operating picture of how a real lead-gen business is built and run.